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The structure of Kanuri society

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Although no attempt was made to measure class differences in the cousin joking relationships, it should be noted here that several informants claimed that the above joking relations were "unbecoming" for good proper behaviour and they did not practise such customs.

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Outside the kinship system a joking relationship may hold between a master and his slave, although this is usual only when the slave is an entertainer of some kind. Informants denied that it occurred when the slave is merely serving his master in an ordinary work situation. Amongst the various occupations, joking relations obtain between smiths and butchers; barber-doctors and smiths; mallams (koranic teacher-priests) and hunters; kola-nut wholesalers and retailers; dyers and tailors; a builder of mud houses and his labourers; a fire-wood seller and his customers; pepper sellers and kola-nut wholesalers. Joking relations also hold between clans such as Ngala's and Magumi; Nguma and T[unknown]ara; Kuburi and T[unknown]ara; Su'urti and Kuburi; or between ethnic groups like Shuwa and Kanuri; Kurdi and Shuwa; Hausa and Fulani; Kanuri and Fulani; Tubu and Monga; Monga and B[unknown]adde; Kanembu and Wasili (Arabs).

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In the above relationships which seem in all cases to cover an area of interrelations involving potential conflicts, the 74 joking takes the form (usually) of the grandparent-grandchild relationship. The younger refers to and addresses the elder as kaka (grandparent) while the elder may refer to the younger as diwo (grandchild) or address him as kaka. Joking between occupations was observed more frequently than between ethnic groups, while no inter-clan joking was seen at all. Most people do not know the clan membership of the people they associate with in their everyday life.

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